The Bridge's Complaint

By Jane Yolen

Trit-trot, trit-trot, trit-trot, all day long. You'd think their demned hooves were made of iron. It fair gives me a headache, it does. Back and forth, back and forth. As if the grass were actually greener on one side one day, on the other the next. Goats really are a monstrous race. . . . It makes me long for the days of Troll.

INTRODUCTION

Once upon a time there were three Billy Goats called Gruff. In the winter they lived in a barn in the valley. When spring came they longed to travel up to the mountains to eat the lush, sweet grass. On their way to the mountains the three Billy Goats Gruff had to cross a rushing river. But there was only one bridge across it, made of wooden planks. And underneath there lived a terrible, ugly, one-eyed troll. Nobody was allowed to cross the bridge without the troll's permission and nobody ever got permission. He always ate them up. . . . In The Bridge's Complaint by Jane Yolen . . . the Bridge finally gets to explain this perilous situation from his . . . or her perspective.

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We never were on more than a generic-name basis. He was Troll. I was Bridge. It takes trolls—and bridges, for that matter – a long time to warm up to full introductions. SO I never had a chance to know his first name before he was . . . well . . . gone. But he was a pleasant sort, for a troll. Knew a lot of stories. Troll stories, of course, are full of blood and food, food and blood. But they were good stories, for all that. Told loudly and with great passion. I really do miss them.

Not that I don't have a few good stories of my own to tell. I mean, I wasn't always a Goat Bridge. Long before that demned tribe arrived to foul my planking, I was a Bridge of Some Consequence. Mme. D'Aulnoy herself traversed my boards. And her friend Mms. Le Prince du Beaumont. Ah – the sound of wheels rolling. There is a memory to treasure.

Non of this trit-trot, trit-trot business.

But then the dear ladies were gone and the meadows, once pied with colorful flowers, were sold to a goat merchant, M. de Gruff. He pastured his demned beasties on both sides of my river. They sharpened

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their horns on my railings, pawed deep into the earthen slopes, and ate up every last one of the flowers. The grass in the meadows was gnawed down to nubbins by those voracious creatures. In other words, they made a desert out of an Eden.

Trit-trot, trit-trot, indeed.

So you can imagine how thrilled I was when Troll showed up, pushing his way upstream from the confluence of the great rivers below.

He wasn't much to look at when he arrived, being young and quite thin. Of course he had the big bran-muffin eyes and the sled-jump nose and the gingko-leaf ears that identify a troll immediately. And when he smiled, there were those moss green teeth, filed to points. But otherwise he was a quite unprepossessing troll.

Trolls are territorial, you know, and when food gets scarce, the young are pushed out by the older, beigger, meaner trolls. Or so my Troll told me, and I have no reason to disbelieve him. He said, "Me dad gave

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a shove when he got hungry. I had to go. Been on the move awhile."

That was an understatement. Actually he had been wading through miles of river before he found me unoccupied. He must have thought it paradise when he saw all those goats.

Not that he could have run across the fields after them. It is a well-kept secret that trolls must have one foot in the water at all times. Troll told me this one night when we were trading tales. They call it water-logging. Troll even sang me a song about it that went something like this:

Two feet wet,
None on shore,
You will live
Evermore.

One foot wet,
One foot dry,
You will never
Need to cry.

Two feet dry –
Say good-bye.

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Well, trolls are actually better at stories than poems. You want good poetry, you have to hang out with boggles or sprites.

Of course the whole thing is a secret and I only tell you this because there are no longer many trolls about. It is a shame, actually. M. Darwin wrote of this disappearing phenomenon, and I, for one, believe it.

So trolls must wait by a river's bank for some creature to cross if they want to eat. That's why trolls and bridges have such an affinity. A bridge means a crossing place, and we are much more stable than fords. Trolls, while not having particularly scientific minds, long ago figured this much out.

So there we were, Troll and I, he dining on M. de Gruff's billy goats, large and small and in-between. And after each meal, after he had a round of belching and farting – which trolls consider good form – he favored me with a troll tale.

He told me about trolls in love and trolls at war—which to the untutored ear can sound much the same.

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He told me a tale about a troll who lived in the waters near Notre-Dame, eating fish and fishermen. But that troll conceived an unlikely passion for the cathedral. He desired to talk to the gargoyles, whom he thought must be cousins of his. He began to waste away with longing for just a single word with his stone kin. So he pulled himself up out of the water and started across the land. After three steps he died, of course. The Parisians used his bones for soup and built a monument where he fell. But he died happy – or so Troll said.

He told me about a troll who had been interviewed by a journalist, and when I asked what paper the piece had appeared in, he giggled, an unlikely sound coming from such a large source. The silly troll, he said, had eaten the man before he wrote the story, not after. We had a good laugh about that!

And then he told me about his mother, about the good times before his father had given him a shove. We cried together. After all, that's what friends are for.

He was so delighted with my company, he tried to compose a troll song to the beauty of my span, but he

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got lost in rhymes about tans/fans/bans and never did finish it. But he was a good teller of tales.

And I am the consummate listener.

I must admit that – except for the day Mme. D'Aulony and Mme. Le Prince du Beaumont traded stories sitting on the banks of my stream, their petit picnic spread out on a blanket – I was never happier.

But the sad fact is that trolls are not very smart. Good storytellers, yes. Pleasant companions, quite. Undemanding friends, absolutely. But they lack upstairs what they have elsewhere. Breadth. They are – alas—really quite stupid. They do not have the slightest understanding of diplomatic dissembling. They do not know how to prevaricate—or to put it more succinctly, they cannot tell a lie. Even with my coaching, Troll would not move downstream a ways and take goats from different parts of the river just to fool, them.

"I like it here with you," he said. "Besides, this is my place."

And not being a troll myself, I couldn't shove him off.

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So the day came when the goats stopped crossing the bridge because it had become too notably dangerous. For a month not a single one went over my span. And while I was delighted to be rid of that constant, demned trit-trot, trit-trot, it worried me to see my friend grow so thin and wan. It got so one could almost read a book through him. He had not even the energy to tell stories.

So I did what I could. Bridges are not a flighty tribe. We are solid and stolid. We stay put. But we have our wiles for all that. One does not arch over a river for so many years without learning something.

I waited until one rather silly young goat strayed a bit too close to my embankments and I called to him.

"Come here, little goat."

He looked about cautiously. "are you a troll?"

"A troll? Do I look like a troll?"

"Well, actually you look like a bridge."

He shook his little nubbined head.

"but you have seen a bridge?"

He giggled. I knew then that I had him.

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"So if you have never seen a troll, how do you know they exist?"

"My mother warned me about them."

I allowed myself a deprecating little laugh. "Mothers! I bet she also warned you about eating tins and paper products and staying out too late at night."

He nodded.

"I am just a bridge," I said. "Immobile and proper. And of course, on my other side is . . . "

"A green meadow?" he asked.

"Greener than any you have ever seen," I said.

That did it. He upped and started over. Trit-trot, trit-trot.

Of course, halfway there, Troll came up and grabbed the fool off and had his first good dinner in a month. Well, good dinner is perhaps an exaggeration. It was only a very little goat. Practically a kid.

If only he had been content with the one. But the next goat I snared for him with my promise of greener pastures was middle sized.

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"Let this one go over," I whispered to Troll, "and you will soon have the entire herd wanting to follow." Even though I mentally cringed at the idea of so many trits and so many trots, I did not want my friend to die.

But that smacked too much of planning, something trolls have no sense about. And lying, which they know nothing of at all.

"Hungry now!" Troll complained, and ate the middle-sized de Gruff goad right then and there.

So when the big goat followed, with horns as sharp as gaffing hooks and a sly twist of mind, it is no wonder that my dear Troll was taken in.

It was not the fall that killed him, of course. It was when the big billy goat of M. de Gruff lifted him out of the water. Troll was dead long before he hit the ground.

My own fault then, you will say, that I must endure this trit-trot, trit-trot all day long. I do not, myself, accept blame. Life is like a river: forever changing. Sometimes it is at flood stage, and sometimes not.

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But if you should hear of another troll who is looking for a home, tell him there is a Bridge of Slight Consequence placed between two green meadows not far from Avignon. Fish abound in the water, and goats gambol on the hills. And if he is not too greedy a troll, he can make a good living here. Besides, he will have an excellent listener to his tales. What troll could resist that?

SOURCE INFORMATION

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